▼ GLASSHOUSE



GAMOCHAS TO THE RESCUE

The first phase of Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's Aashirvad Yatra concluded on March 9 and was, by all accounts, a hit. Every stop drew a sea of people, and even conceding that 70 per cent were BJP cadre, the turnout spoke volumes about the party's organisational depth in the state. Opposition parties dismissed it as the dividend of five years of beneficiary schemes. But during the yatra, the CM himself became a beneficiary. People pressed food, water, cold drinks, ice cream and fruit into his hands. Tossing security protocol out of the window, Sarma ate and drank whatever was offered, sending crowds into a frenzy. All that love, though, came at a cost. At every stop, people were grabbing at his hands with such force that both his wrists were left with scratches and wounds. A solution was soon found—two Assamese *gamochas* (towels), tied tight around the wrists.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ THE HOLI SPIRIT

COLOURFUL REMARKS

Holi in Gorakhpur this March came with a splash of political humour. Chief minister **Yogi Adityanath**, after performing Holika dahan aarti amid a shower of rose petals and 'Jai Shri Ram' chants, turned to Bhojpuri actor-turned-local party MP **Ravi Kishan** with a playful jab. "Kishan can sing and dance anywhere and earn money," he said, "but Baba wins only when the people prosper." The crowd roared. Kishan had set it up nicely, praising Yogi for bringing Japanese and Singaporean investment to the state and urging the DJs to play the evergreen Holi number, *Rang Barse*. The banter between the two isn't new. On an earlier occasion, Yogi had mocked the actor-neta for making a "swadeshi" pitch while sporting a foreign watch. Kishan may be master of the song-and-dance routine but nobody owns the political stage like Yogi.

